bunch from Haryana to Bihar, and all at around the same time. This is evident also from the edicts at all sites being in the same dialect, set down from a common exemplar and thus involving no translation changes. In the earlier rock edicts, a variety of dialects had been used.[3] Had adverse feedback modified the earlier way of transcribing? Had the variety of dialects suited to each region unsatisfactorily altered the meanings of the messages? Only speculation is possible on the reasons for the new singularity: by the time of the pillar edicts Ashoka seems likely to have been an impatient and imperious old sovereign who wanted his words conveying precisely what he wanted to say and be done.

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The places where these pillars were set up do not seem to have been in the vicinity of important provincial cities or major settlements, as was the case with many of the major rock edicts, which seems at odds with the pillar messages being non-sectarian addresses to the populace at large. Pataliputra, Hastinapur, and Mathura, all important settlements of the day, were bypassed and the monoliths put in locations entirely of a different character. At Rampurva, endowed with two Ashokan pillars, one of them inscribed, no vestiges of buildings were found in the vicinity. There does not appear to have been an ancient town at the location. A couple of mounds nearby contained no structures, only bits of potsherds, bricks, beads, and burnt ore. Practically the only structural remnants that emerged from excavations at Rampurva were around the pillars, in the form of an extensive brick floor of Mauryan times and an ancient well made of terracotta rings. These were in the trenches that had been made to remove the pillars from the sand and water morass in which they were found buried.[4]

One reason for lack of detail about the contexts of the pillar edicts may be that some were not found *in situ* or even close to their original locations.